Meerza Saduck who some years ago went to England to study medicine has just returned. He came from England to Constantinople by way of the Rhine and the Danube which two rivers have now a canal connecting them, so that a man can pass through the heart of Europe by river navigation.[111] He states that the Russian government have a similar contemplation between the Don and Volga.[112] This will connect the Caspian with the Black Sea and if it is opened we shall I hope be able to send Persian grain from this province to England by water carriage; it would be shipped at Astard (or some port near it) the nearest port to Ardebil. And as this is near one of the most extensive and productive grain districts in the north of Persia, the wheat could often be delivered at the water side at about S 10/ or S 12/ the Q^r and from thence you would have water carriage to London. Grain would not be the only Persian produce then exported which is now useless on account of the heavy land carriage. Had the countries about the Don and Volga been in the hands of any other European power except Russia this canal would have been opened long ago. But I have no hope from that stupid, barbarous, and tyrannical government, who with unbounded resources at their command appear to do less for agriculture and commerce than even the Asiatics. Who else with the power they have had now more than a hundred years, would not have opened a water communication into central Asia when the whole expense was that of cutting a canal not more than a hundred miles long.

The Greeks have driven almost every one else out of the trade here, they have beaten even the Persians who had a considerable trade in British manufactures from Constantinople. Mr Ede does a little in what you would in America call *notions* (I believe) viz little lots of guns pistols, some times tea and sugar and other things but not much in the staple trade of the country, Cotton manufactures, which are sold in bulk and chiefly for the interior.

A month ago the Prince talked of going to a place called Sir-Aub where there is a most abundant spring of pure hot-water over which a bath has been constructed. It is in a cool upland district about a hundred miles off in the direction of the Caspian, and is a part of the corn country mentioned above. The arrival

111 The "Ludwigs-Donau-Main Kanal" opened for navigation July 15th, 1846, cf. H. Brüschwein, *Der Gedanke einer Rhein-Main-Donau Verbindung in seiner geschichtlicher Entwicklung*, Regensberg, 1928, p. 59. Cf. also Gaston Raphael, "La grande voie fluviale Rhin-Danube" in *L'action nationale*, t. 18 (1922), p. 165 ff., where its subsequent history is described.

112 This canal has never been built. Discussed from the days of Peter the Great, its proposed construction reached its highest point in 1929, cf. A. S. Aksamityi, *The Volga-Don deep waterway*, Moscow, 1929, where the beginning of the project is actually announced, as well as plans for its completion by 1935–36. It is interesting to note that a 1939 speech by Molotoff to the 18th Conference of the All-Union Communist Party includes the official reasons for the failure to complete the canal project.

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